

DTD Education Lane Governance Document

1. Purpose

The Education lane exists to make DTD useful before trainer matching.

It is not a generic dog training blog, obedience academy, or entertainment content library. It is a decision-support product for new dog owners.

Its role is to help new owners:

- understand what kind of problem they may have
- avoid making situations worse by accident
- take safer and clearer next steps
- build calm early routines
- know when education is enough
- know when trainer or veterinary support is needed
- become better prepared before engaging a trainer

The Education lane supports the DTD ecosystem by improving owner readiness, building trust, and guiding users toward better trainer matching when needed.

2. Locked Product Definition

DTD Education is a structured guidance system for new dog owners.

It helps users build calm foundations, read canine behaviour more accurately, manage common early stress points, and make better real-world handling decisions before and alongside professional trainer support.

The key differentiator is:

Before users choose a trainer, DTD helps them understand what kind of problem they actually have.

3. Target User

The Education lane is for:

- first-time dog owners
- new puppy owners
- recently adopted dog owners
- owners in the early adjustment phase
- owners who feel confused, stressed, inconsistent, or unsure what to do next

It is not primarily for:

- professional dog trainers
 - advanced handlers
 - owners looking mainly for tricks
 - owners seeking entertainment-based obedience drills
 - users needing urgent behaviour intervention
 - users seeking veterinary diagnosis
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4. Strategic Role Within DTD

The Education lane acts as:

- the main acquisition hook
- the trust-building layer
- the owner readiness layer
- the pre-matching decision-support layer
- the bridge into trainer services
- a qualifier that helps users understand when professional support is appropriate

It must support trainer matching, not replace trainers.

It must help the user become a better client for trainers by clarifying the issue, improving observation, and encouraging timely escalation when needed.

5. Core Objectives

All Education content must support at least one of the following objectives.

Objective 1: Reduce Owner Confusion

Help users identify what may be happening.

Examples:

- normal puppy adjustment
- fear
- over-arousal
- boredom
- unmet needs
- poor environment setup
- illness red flags
- trainer-level behaviour concerns

Objective 2: Improve Owner Judgment

Help users make better next-step decisions in real situations.

Content should answer:

- What should the owner notice?
- What should the owner stop doing?
- What should the owner change?
- What should the owner do next?
- What should the owner track?
- When is outside help needed?

Objective 3: Prevent Accidental Escalation

Teach owners how not to make problems worse.

Examples:

- do not force exposure when the dog is scared
- do not punish after-the-fact accidents
- do not confuse fear with stubbornness
- do not give too much freedom too soon
- do not reward the wrong moment
- do not delay help when red flags appear

Objective 4: Build Calm Routines

Help owners create practical systems at home and in public.

Examples:

- safe home setup
- rest zones
- toileting routines
- predictable daily structure
- calm departures and arrivals
- safe public handling

Objective 5: Identify When Education Is Not Enough

Make clear when users should seek:

- professional trainer support
- veterinary advice
- qualified behaviour support
- urgent help

The Education lane must never imply that all problems can be solved through self-guided content.

Objective 6: Prepare Users for Trainer Matching

Help users become ready to choose and work with a trainer.

Education content should help users prepare:

- problem summaries
 - trigger lists
 - behaviour logs
 - videos or examples to show a trainer
 - goals for trainer support
 - questions to ask before booking
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6. Content Boundaries

6.1 What Belongs Inside the Education Lane

Education content may include:

- new owner decision rules
- common early problem recognition
- mistake-prevention guidance
- environment setup guidance
- simple routines
- scenario-based decision support
- checklists
- observation prompts
- escalation thresholds
- trainer-readiness tools
- beginner-safe handling guidance
- source-backed safety guidance

6.2 What Does Not Belong Inside the Education Lane

Education content must not centre on:

- tricks
 - obedience entertainment
 - generic puppy blog content
 - long expert lectures
 - heavy theory
 - breed encyclopaedia content
 - trainer-level behaviour modification
 - serious aggression protocols
 - medical diagnosis
 - veterinary treatment instructions
 - claims that replace professional assessment
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7. Content Format Standards

The Education lane must be mobile-first and action-first.

Preferred structure:

1. Real-world scenario
2. What the owner may be seeing
3. What not to do
4. What to do next
5. When to seek help
6. Optional trainer-readiness output

Content should use:

- short lessons
- clear headings
- plain English
- active voice
- short paragraphs
- narrow bullet points
- practical examples
- decision rules
- checklists
- simple “if/then” logic where useful

Content should avoid:

- dense theory
- unnecessary scientific detail
- long paragraphs
- vague motivational advice
- unsupported claims
- inflated course language
- advice that sounds more certain than the evidence allows

8. Tone and Language Rules

The tone must be:

- calm
- practical
- non-judgmental
- beginner-safe
- direct
- supportive without being sentimental
- realistic about limits

The content must not shame owners.

Avoid language that implies the dog is:

- stubborn
- dominant

- naughty on purpose
- manipulative
- trying to “win”
- acting out of spite

Use language that focuses on:

- stress
 - unmet needs
 - unclear routines
 - fear
 - over-arousal
 - poor timing
 - environment mismatch
 - owner decision points
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9. Safety and Escalation Rules

Education content must include escalation guidance where relevant.

9.1 Veterinary Escalation

Content must direct users to seek veterinary advice when signs may involve health, pain, or illness.

Examples:

- severe lethargy
- repeated vomiting
- appetite loss
- sudden collapse
- breathing difficulty
- suspected toxin ingestion
- sudden behaviour change
- ongoing pain signs
- symptoms that persist or worsen

The Education lane must not diagnose illness.

9.2 Trainer or Behaviour Escalation

Content must direct users toward trainer or behaviour support when issues are persistent, unsafe, worsening, or beyond beginner management.

Examples:

- repeated fear responses
- growling, snapping, or biting
- severe separation distress
- ongoing reactivity
- resource guarding

- repeated failed owner attempts
- owner feels unsafe or overwhelmed

9.3 Emergency Disclaimer

Where relevant, content should clearly state that urgent safety, medical, or aggression concerns require professional help rather than self-guided education.

10. Evidence and Source Standards

The Education lane must not present unsupported claims as verified fact.

Claims requiring source support include:

- toxin risks
- puppy vaccination guidance
- socialisation windows
- illness red flags
- puppy development claims
- punishment risk claims
- separation distress claims
- health, diet, or veterinary guidance
- cost estimates
- safety recommendations

Preferred source hierarchy:

1. Official veterinary, animal welfare, or government sources
2. Veterinary associations
3. Peer-reviewed or professional behaviour sources
4. Reputable training or welfare organisations
5. Secondary sources only where primary sources are unavailable

Placeholder citations must not be published as final references.

11. DTD-Specific Differentiation Rules

Every Education item should help DTD answer at least one of these questions for the user:

- What kind of problem might this be?
- Is this normal early adjustment?
- Is this a setup issue?
- Is this a fear issue?
- Is this over-arousal?
- Is this a health concern?
- Is this something a trainer should help with?
- What information should I collect before contacting a trainer?
- What should I change before I book help?

If content does not support these questions, it risks becoming generic and should be revised or excluded.

12. Relationship to Trainer Matching

The Education lane must connect naturally to trainer matching without forcing sales pressure.

Appropriate connection points:

- "If this keeps happening, prepare this information before contacting a trainer."
- "A trainer can help if this pattern repeats despite routine changes."
- "Use this checklist to describe the issue clearly."
- "This may need professional support if safety is affected."

Inappropriate connection points:

- fear-based upselling
 - implying every issue requires paid help
 - implying the course replaces trainers
 - recommending a specific trainer type without enough information
 - making guarantees about outcomes
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13. Content Governance Rules

Before content is approved, it must pass the following checks.

13.1 Objective Check

Does the content support at least one locked Education objective?

If no, remove or revise.

13.2 Specificity Check

Does the content address a real new-owner situation?

If it sounds like generic dog advice, revise.

13.3 Decision Check

Does it help the owner decide what to notice, change, stop, or do next?

If no, revise.

13.4 Escalation Check

Does it clearly state when education is not enough?

If relevant but missing, revise.

13.5 Evidence Check

Are health, safety, cost, development, or behaviour claims properly sourced?

If no, verify before publishing.

13.6 Trainer-Readiness Check

Does it help the user become more prepared for trainer support where appropriate?

If not, add a trainer-readiness prompt or remove the trainer connection.

14. Approved Content Types

The Education lane may include:

- short lessons
 - decision trees
 - owner checklists
 - behaviour observation logs
 - mistake-prevention cards
 - escalation guides
 - scenario-based guidance
 - “what to try first” guides
 - “what to tell a trainer” templates
 - “when to seek help” prompts
 - simple household routine planners
 - trainer-readiness worksheets
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15. Prohibited Content Types

The Education lane should not publish:

- advanced behaviour modification protocols
 - aggression treatment plans
 - medical diagnosis content
 - medication advice
 - breed stereotyping
 - dominance-based claims
 - punishment-heavy advice
 - unsupported guarantees
 - trainer-replacement messaging
 - generic filler articles created only for SEO
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16. Implementation Separation

The Education lane must remain clearly separated from other DTD website lanes.

Education Lane

Purpose:

- owner guidance
- decision support
- readiness building
- trust building

Directory / Trainer Lane

Purpose:

- trainer discovery
- trainer comparison
- trainer contact or matching
- service exploration

The Education lane may link into the Directory lane only when the content naturally reaches an escalation or trainer-readiness point.

17. Success Measures

The Education lane should be assessed by whether it improves user readiness and trust.

Potential success measures:

- registration conversion
- lesson completion
- checklist completion
- trainer-readiness checklist use
- click-through to trainer search after escalation prompts
- reduced bounce from new-owner content
- user self-report of clarity or confidence
- saved or downloaded tools
- return visits to decision-support pages

The goal is not content volume.

The goal is useful owner decision support.

18. Editorial Rule

If a piece of content can be found as generic advice on thousands of dog training websites, it should not be published in that form.

To become DTD Education content, it must be reframed around:

- the owner's real situation
 - the decision they need to make
 - what mistake to avoid
 - what next step to take
 - when professional help may be needed
 - how this prepares them for trainer support
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19. Final Governance Statement

DTD Education exists to help new dog owners make better early decisions.

It should not try to be the internet's largest dog training library.

It should become the clearest, most useful pre-trainer guidance layer for new dog owners who need structure, calm, and better judgment before they choose professional support.